

SELF CENTRIC

With artists increasingly appearing in their own works, the thin line between self-expression and narcissism is blurring



and Bose Krishnamachari have, in the past, experimented by directly engaging with the self. But increasingly self-inspection in art is making a direct leap on to the canvas.

Young artists like Kapse, Pushpamala, Anju Dodiya, Abir Karmakar, Sanjeev Sonpimpale and Hema Upadhyay, among others, have seen their work peopled by their own faces and personalities. Whether it is through self-portraits, photo-performances or marginal intrusions into the artwork, the creative lot is slowly blurring the thin line between self-reference and self-reverence.

STEPPING INTO CANVAS: Kapse plays the bespectacled jokester (left); Pushpamala in her 'photo-performance' (below)



MANDAR DEODHAR

■ By Kimi Dangor

His clean-shaven head and bespectacled face sits atop a heavy muscular body. His jeering grin and underwear-clad figure transforms into a suited-booted entity in the next frame. No, this is no underwear model or bodybuilder at work, but artist Rajendra Kapse giving a new definition to the term 'self-expression'. All his canvases have one thing in common—Kapse himself. The artist becomes the protagonist and his 'self' surfaces in every frame.

Exaggerated self-portraits or simply vignettes of self-expression—you may wonder as you view

works of Bangalore-based artist Pushpamala N. In her 'photo-performances', the artist appears in every frame, changing guise to play a whip-cracking Jayalalithaa, a Kannada film actor, a goddess, and even a runaway Bollywood belle, painstakingly recreating historical, religious and fictional characters.

While the art of self-portraiture has seen painters like Rembrandt, Van Gogh and Cezanne explore the realm of reality, Indian artists like Amrita Sher-Gill and Bhupen Khakhar have highlighted their compositions by stepping into the canvas and becoming a part of the proceedings. Other contemporary artists like Jitish Kallat

Art writer and curator Jasmine Shah Varma believes that the contemporary artist makes a comment and gives his take on the present circumstances or the human condition, and in doing so sees himself at the centre of it. "Art is an extension of the artist's self and his/her view of the world. It's no surprise that artists include themselves in their paintings. Yesterday, I saw a sculpture where the artist told me the flying bird in the work was him," she says.

Kapse, who confesses to having always harboured the secret desire of becoming an actor, has in turn transferred his fancy to the canvas. "Here, I'm the hero. I've put my